

Singh is Kinng—shot mostly in Gold Coast City—selected his action coordinator from resumes sent by the Australian Trade Commission. He settled on Australian stunt coordinator Danny Baldwin, who has worked on *The Ghost and the Darkness*. One of the stunts had Kumar jumping from one moving elevator to another within a mall. Says Shah: "I was there when Akshay was performing the stunt. He took me aside and said he felt born again with the action he had done." The stunts were coordinated in a scientific fashion, first storyboarded, then rehearsed without cameras and then actually performed. There was always a safety supervisor—a former world kickboxing champion—on board. "The beauty of the stunts is that they are high-impact and yet full of humour, not graphic, but cartoonish," says Shah, whose four major action sequences cost him Rs 16 crore in total.

Apoorva Lakhia, who made the gritty street-smart *Shootout In*

Lokhandwala, also found his man for the car chases in the forthcoming *Mission Istanbul*, a commando caper involving the Al Qaida, RAW and CIA, on the World Wide Web. George Aguilar, who choreographed *Die Hard 3*'s car chases, was his choice for a stunt that involves a car doing a 360-degree turn and then going over another exploding car to fall into the Bosphorus River. "We couldn't get him, so our own fight masters, Ejaz Gulab and Javed Karim, choreographed the sequence," says Lakhia, who also had his actors, Viveik Oberoi and Zayed Khan, jumping on to a helicopter from the fifth floor of a burning warehouse and falling into the minus-10 degree Bosphorus from a height of 70 ft, as the chopper explodes above them. Coordinating the se-

quence required five deep sea divers, a floating ambulance, a Navy Seal boat and the fire brigade. The actors also rappelled down the 67th floor of the 102-storey Koza Plaza in the heart of Istanbul, where they shot for 45 days. "Zayed and Viveik competed with each other. If Zayed jumped from an eight-storey hospital on to a moving truck, Viveik was fighting 40 men, who were flown in from India and trained for two weeks," says Lakhia, who picked up technical expertise about camera angles and safety precautions while working as assistant director on the stunt team of *Die Hard 3*.

What explains the return of action in Bollywood? Much of it has to do with the success of *Dhoom* and *Krrish*. The designer action, says strategist

Prabhat Choudhary of Spice, a marketing communication agency, is explained by the "growing obsession with the perfectly sculpted form". "It's comparable to pornography and

RACE

ACTION STATIONS With 35 per cent of the budget spent on action sequences, the film has Saif Ali Khan (below) jumping off buildings and even a cliff.

FIGHT MASTER Allan Amin, who first rose to fame with the bikes-and-babes stylised thriller, *Dhoom*.

BUDGET
Rs 42 cr

